After a bunch of direct-to-digital works, Bhardwaj is now itching to make a film for the big screen. Going by current box office diktats, it will have to be a "macho film" or at least a provocative one. "If I want to make a big film and create a huge spectacle, I need to think of a male character, otherwise I won't get money," he says, with a rarely-seen honesty.

Bhardwaj hasn't shied from wearing his politics on his sleeve. It's why you will see him and singer-wife Rekha Bhardwaj perform in Srinagar as part of the Bharat Jodo Yatra. The times they are a-changin', and Bhardwaj finds himself challenged. Even the freedom that streaming platforms afforded him now comes with caveats. "They want stars and more commercial subjects," he says. "Ultimately, it is a business and they want to grow." But then what is an artistic journey without adversities? Says Bhardwaj, "One thing is you force yourself to adapt [to the times]. Your basic default nature makes you realise that if you don't say something in the film, how will you survive? You become even smarter and cleverer." ■

Suhani Singh



THEATRE

Dial M for Motherhood

Koel Purie Rinchet's play *Mummy's Dead, Long Live Mummy* is a dark comedy about motherhood that hits the spot

As Koel Purie Rinchet waited for her debut novel to be published and then waited again on the sets of Zoya Akhtar's *The Archies*, in which she plays Betty's mother Alice Cooper, she found herself with an undervalued luxury—time. "The long breaks away from family, my child and being away from the routine of having to organise house or social life [while shooting] led to periods where I could just sit and create," she says. The result is that the actor and author has added two new labels—playwright and theatre producer—to her resume with the dark comedy *Mummy's Dead, Long Live Mummy*. After premiering in Paris in March this year, Koel joined hands with Ira Dubey's Lila Natak Company to do a three-city run in India. The play will soon head to London.

Featuring four mothers unloading their experiences raising kids, all of it single-handedly, the play offers honesty, insight, an abundance of laughs, but also empathy and gratitude. Koel is 'Maya and Jai's mummy', the most riotous of the lot, who refers to her kids as 'hyenas' and 'coyotes'; Melinda Mayor plays a lesbian single parent struggling to shoot a sex education video for her teenage daughter; Sosi and Kiki's mommy (Laura Woody) is a god-fearing parent who judges others; and there's an overwhelmed young mother (Viviane Bossina) battling post-partum depression and desperate for advice.

> Mummy's Dead features four mothers unloading their experiences raising kids, all of it single-handedly

The play, says Koel, emerged from a need to shatter the universal myth around mothers being infallible superheroes. "Don't judge anyone else's parenting, for no two mothers or kids are the same," she says. A mother to an 11-year-old daughter herself, Koel lays bare a range of emotions women feel, and not all of it is joyous. "It hasn't been easy for me. It has been a lot of struggle and continues to be, but thank god for my child," she says. "Kids adjust much faster than parents do. They become your greatest teacher. She saves me and shows the way. [Without her] I'd be a completely crazy person flying off with no feeling of connectedness and home."

Mummy's Dead also highlights Koel's creative spurt in Paris, which has been her home for six years now. Having lived in Tokyo before, it's in the City of Light that she found herself "a tribe" she can connect with. "What you need is to be seen, and by people you like and respect," she adds. She also credits "the polarity of the city" for creating an atmosphere conducive for her to write. "At one end, it's the city of love, but it's also the city of aloofness," she says. "It's a city that prides itself on being equal; it's also a divided society; it's cosmopolitan, but also heavily ghettoised."

Whatever the situation, she always finds herself, in her own words, "in a good place". "When I was younger, I didn't see the power of just being me. I always wanted to be something else. I did arthouse films when I wanted to cross over and do Bollywood films," she says. With wisdom has come assuredness. "Now everything I do, I finish. I have the confidence to say that the work must reach its final destination. No one is going to do it for you. You got to do it yourself." Just like mommies. ■

Suhani Singh

